

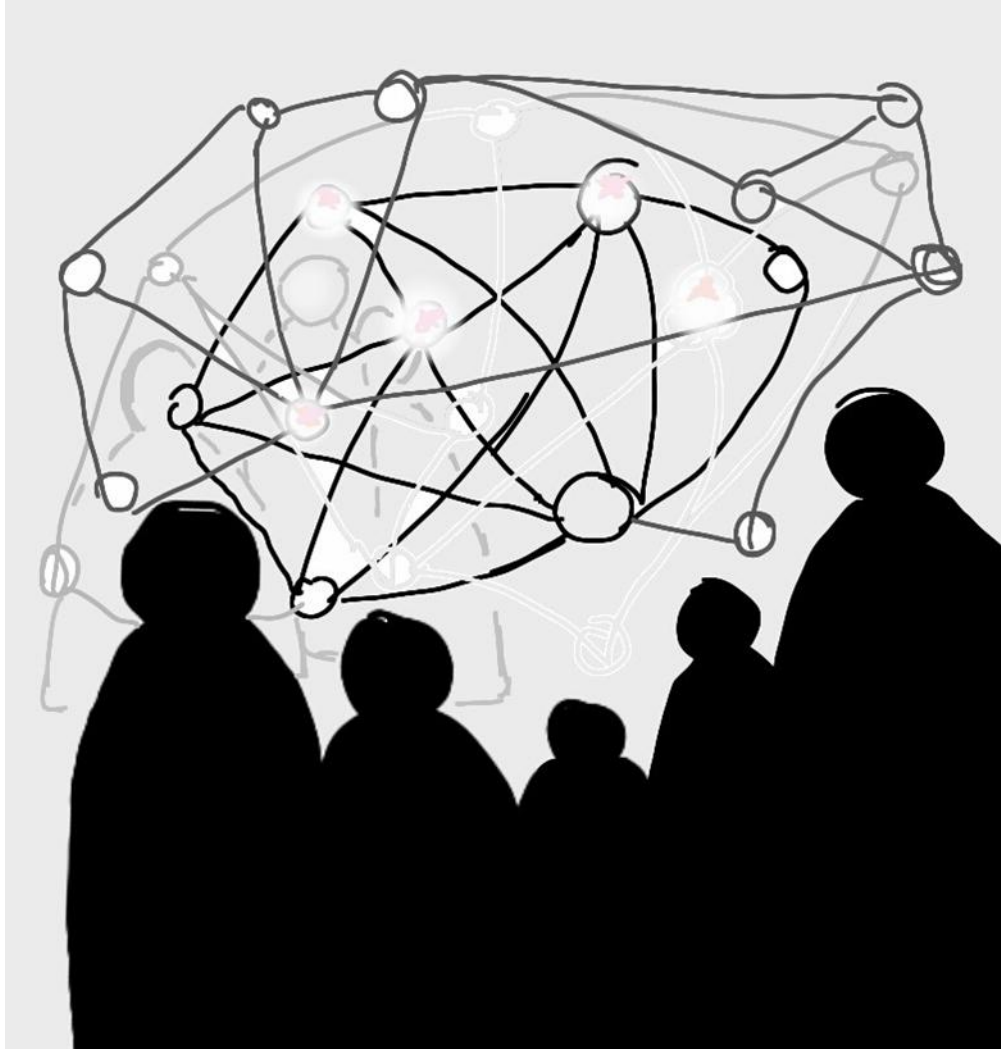
AI 507: Artificial Intelligence and Society



#11 AI in politics

Associate Prof. Dr. Lena Frischlich

Flashlight



Flashlight

Digital platforms

Social media History of social media

Platform-fragmentation

“Genres” of social media

Social media and wellbeing

Complex relationships

Windows of sensitivity

Active versus passive use

Social media and political participation

PINGS framework

“News-will-find-me” perception

Incidental news exposure

Political knowledge

Political participation

Social media use

In general

For political participation

Hate speech on social media

Definition

Opportunity structures

Multi-modality

Platform features

Affordances

Anonymity

Visibility

Hate speech in the Danish public sphere

Implicit versus explicit hate speech

Sexual and gender minorities

**Do you have questions to
last week?**



Then let's get started!

After today's lecture, you will hopefully have...

- ❑ ... initial insights into AI in public administrations
- ❑ ... gained a better understanding what political communication is – and how AI affects it
- ❑ ... a better understanding of “misinformation”
- ❑ ... discussed how AI can affect misinformation dynamics

AI in public administration

Public administration (AI-watch.EU, Madan & Ashok, 2023)

= “public organisations that implement government policies and may contribute to its development”

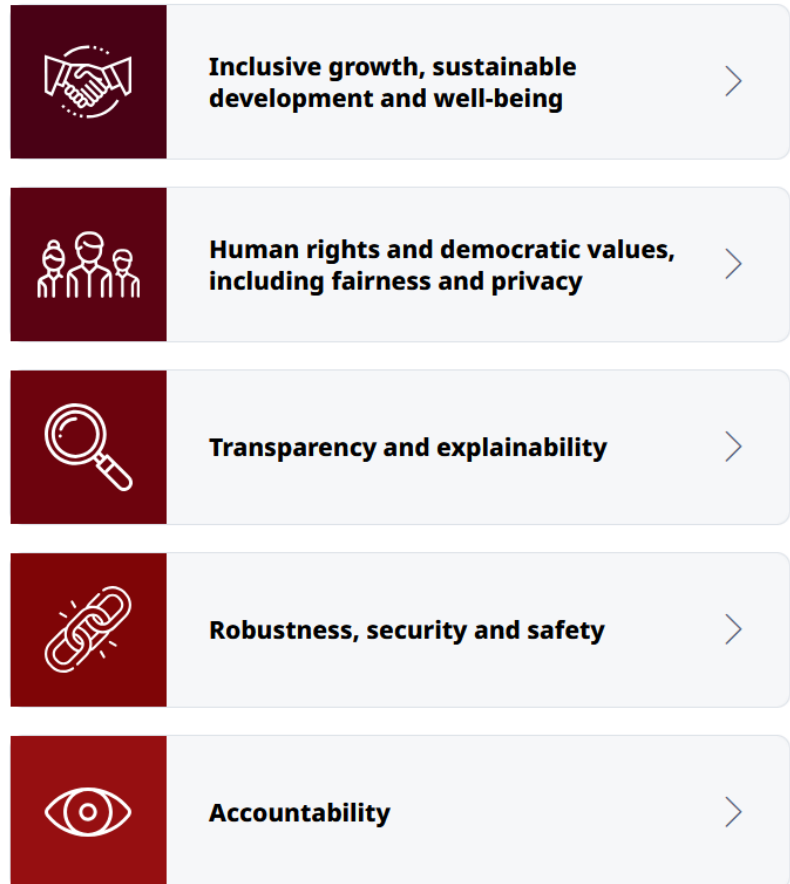
AI has the potential to be an extremely useful - or even disruptive - technology

- enabler for seeking efficiency and effectiveness in the management and delivery of public services
- E.g., automate simple and repetitive cognitive activities (Odense Kommune uses it to issue bills) freeing-up labour time for more high-value activities
- augment the predictive capabilities, enhancing data-driven decision-making
- support user-centric service personalisation, increasing the effectiveness of public service delivery

Principles

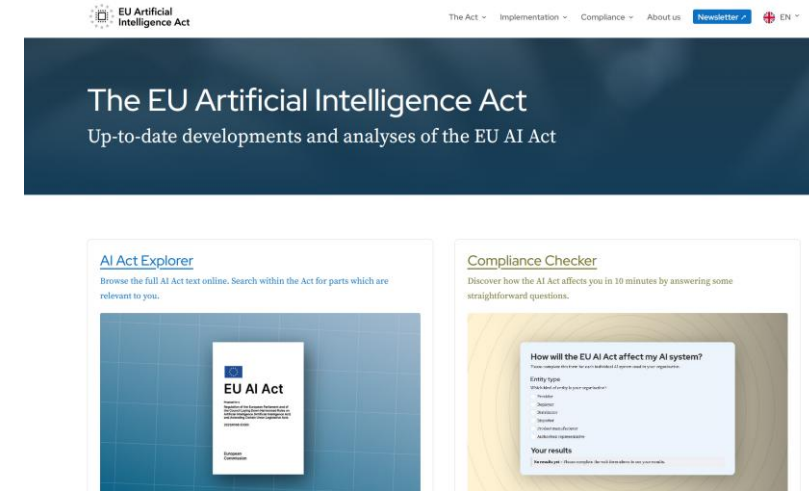
(OECD; European Commission. Joint Research Centre 2023; Public sector Tech Watch 2024)

Values-based principles



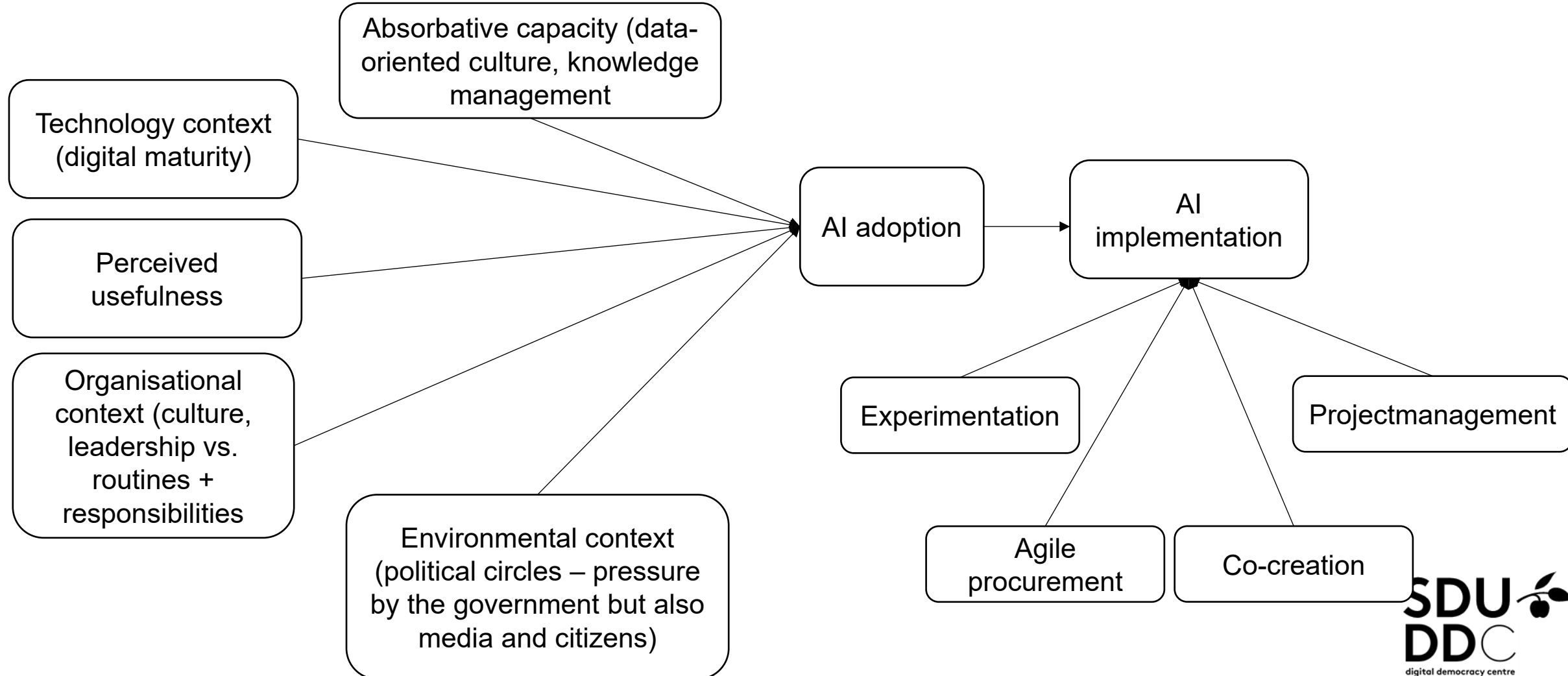
Informs standardization processes such as

- ISO/IEC1
- IEEE
- Currently working groups but expect to provide standards for, for example, bias mitigation



So, what do we know about adoption? (Madan & Ashok, 2023)

Systematic literature review, $n = 73$ publications



What do you think? How will the future in Odense look like?

(Knudsen, 2025)

- Large project by Odense & Aarhus municipality (DDC * TrygFonden fellowship)
- Development of four scenarios for the digital commune in 2030

Fire alternative fremtider

“Aistrup”: Focus is on efficiency and “doing what works”.

AI is implemented when increasing efficacy/ having significant benefits, its diligent and stable.

Hvad:
Sigte

Effektivitet

Hvordan:
Organisering
Fælles, samlet,
offentligt ledet



KOMMUNE
MOD 2030

Transformation

“Smart welfare”: Political ambitions and welfare values are driving the use of AI. AI is implemented to create a society that works for people. Denmark is leading and municipalities are key drivers

“Tech-drive”: Market & tech sector are driving for change, large range of applications, led by a few tech-giants. AI is implemented in the form of buying the right applications (while adhering to ethics and budget)

e #2
Irive

Individuelt, fragmenteret,
markeds- og teknologidrevet

“Opinion power”: conscious citizens have strong opinions about AI. There are many competing agendas- Tech giants still have a commercial agenda, but hype and awe have faded and diverse and freedom-oriented approaches. Municipalities are part of the debate – so are critical citizens

AI and political communication

Political communication is... (McNair, 1995; Norris, 2001)

...the transmission of information

- among politicians
- the news media
- and the public

Can be

- Top-down (e.g., from government to citizens)
- Vertical (e.g., between politicians)
- Upward (e.g., from public opinion to politicians)
- A communication system

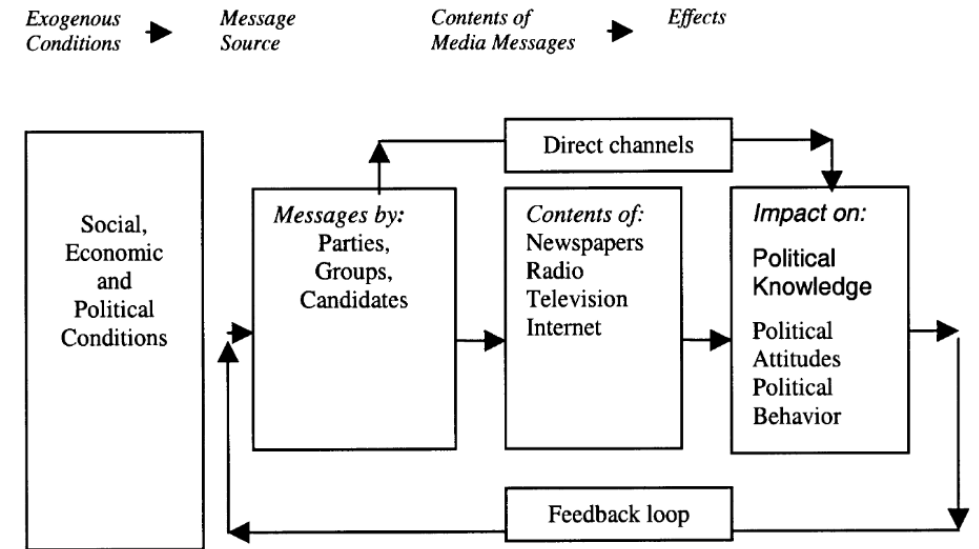
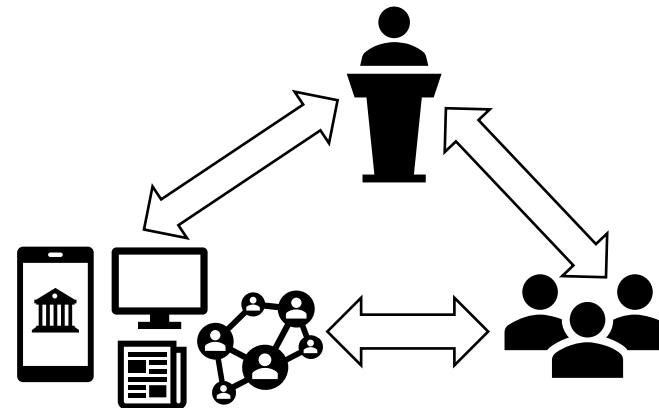


Figure 1
Systems model of political communication process



Communication by politicians is typically strategic communication

(Maier et al., 2023; McNair, 1995; Marcinkowski & Metag, 2014;

Stier et al. 2025)

- Overarching objective: influence the political decision-making process
- Communication is, at least partially, driven by rational considerations: when the perceived benefits are larger than the perceived risks, communication becomes more likely
- E.g., candidates engage in negative campaigning when they hope to get votes for it
- Behavioral opportunities also matter
- Sometimes candidates engage in negative campaigning despite its potentially negative effects on relevant stakeholders

AI can affect this system in many ways (Norris, 2001)

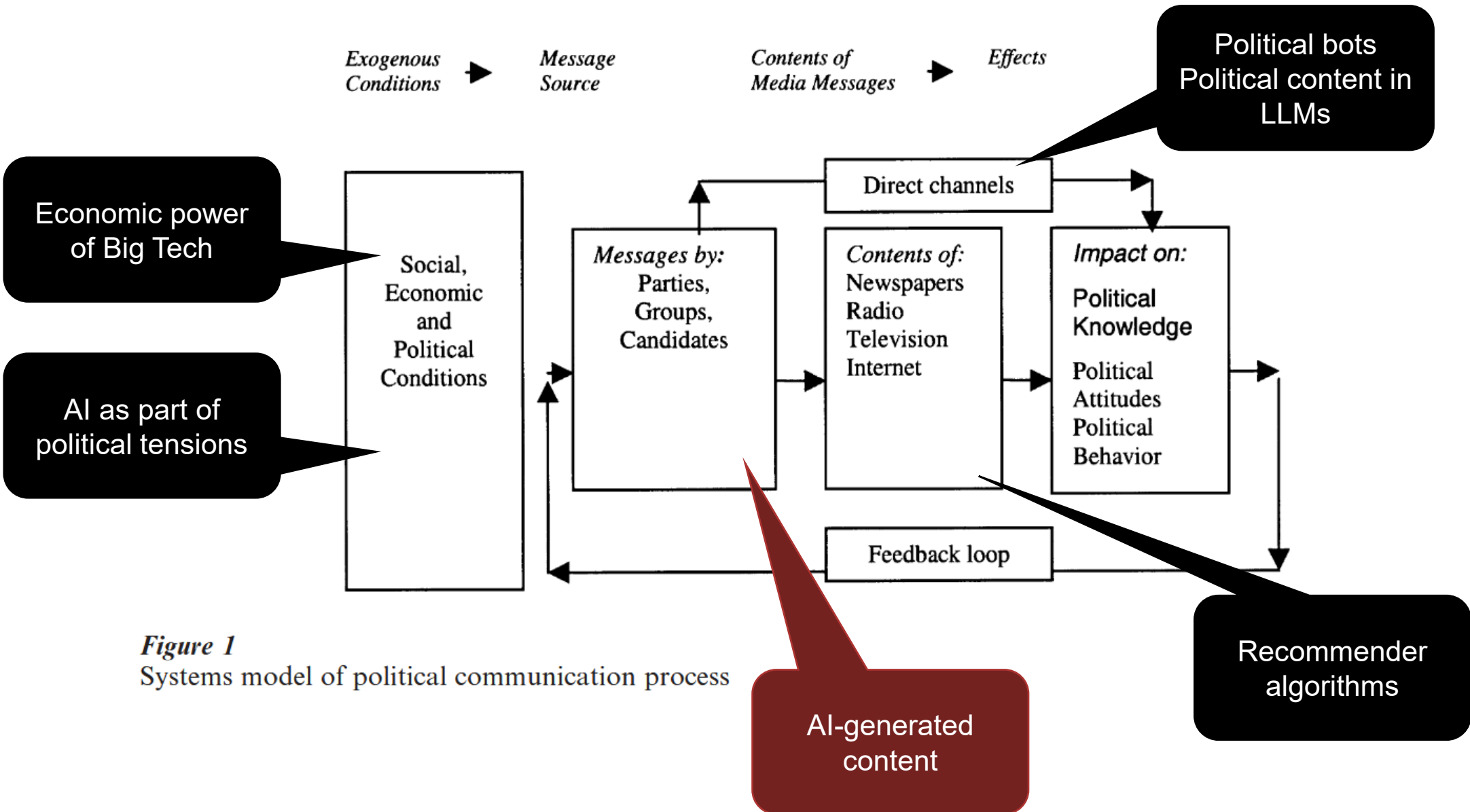


Figure 1
Systems model of political communication process

AI-generated content has become more “normal” in political communication



<https://www.npr.org/2025/02/26/nx-s1-5309695/trump-gaza-video>

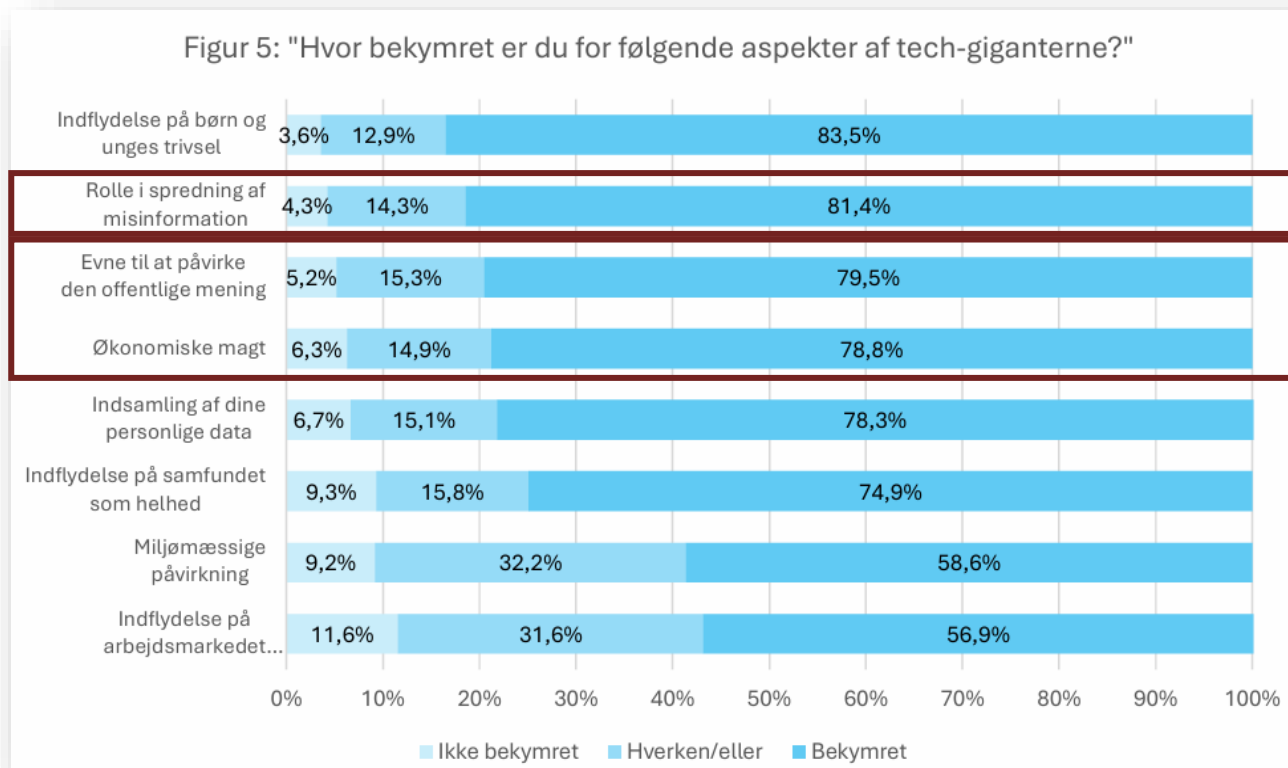


AI generated images of President Donald Trump shared on X via the official @WhiteHouse channel depict the President as a Jedi and the Pope. Credit - @WhiteHouse / X

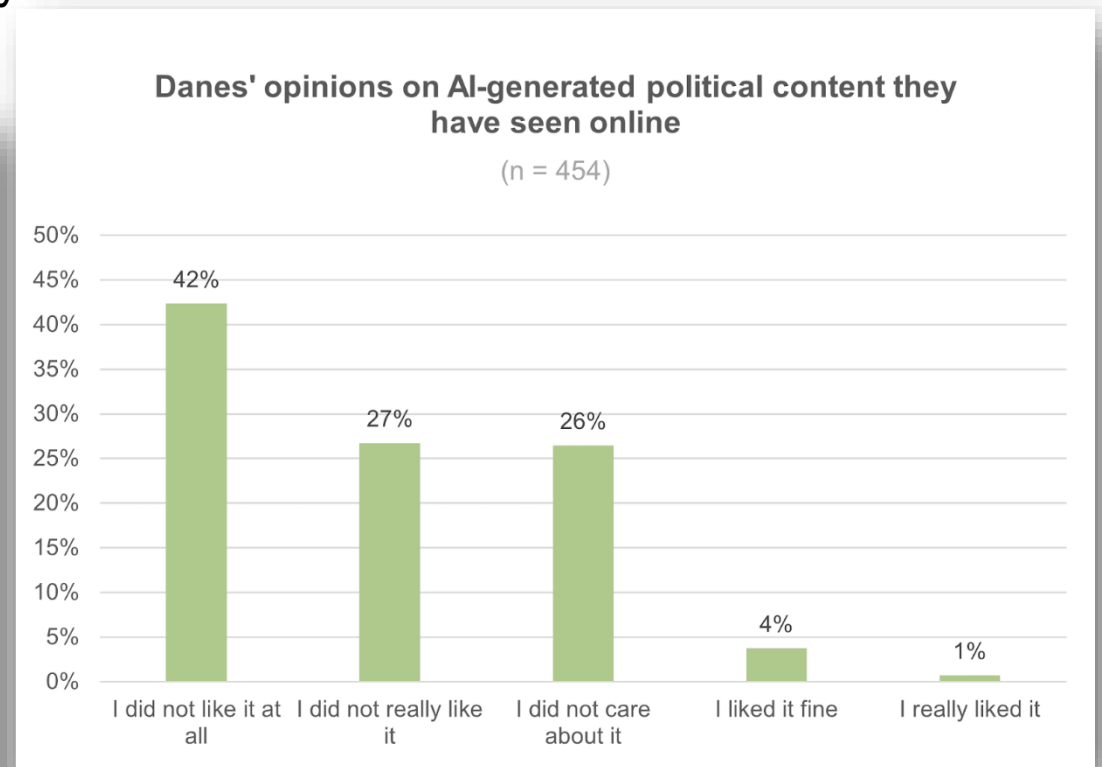
But what do the Danes actually think about it?

(Filstrup Høllsberg et al., 2025; Johansen et al., *in prep*)

- Part of DDC's „Citizens, digitalisation and AI“ project survey
- Regular surveys with ~1200-1400 Danes >18



Notes. $N = 1201$, representative for age, gender, and region, June 2025



Notes. $N = 1494$, representative for age, gender, and region, March 2026

**Questions before the
break?**



Mis-and disinformation

Misinformation

(Freiling et al., 2023; Nussbaum, 2011)

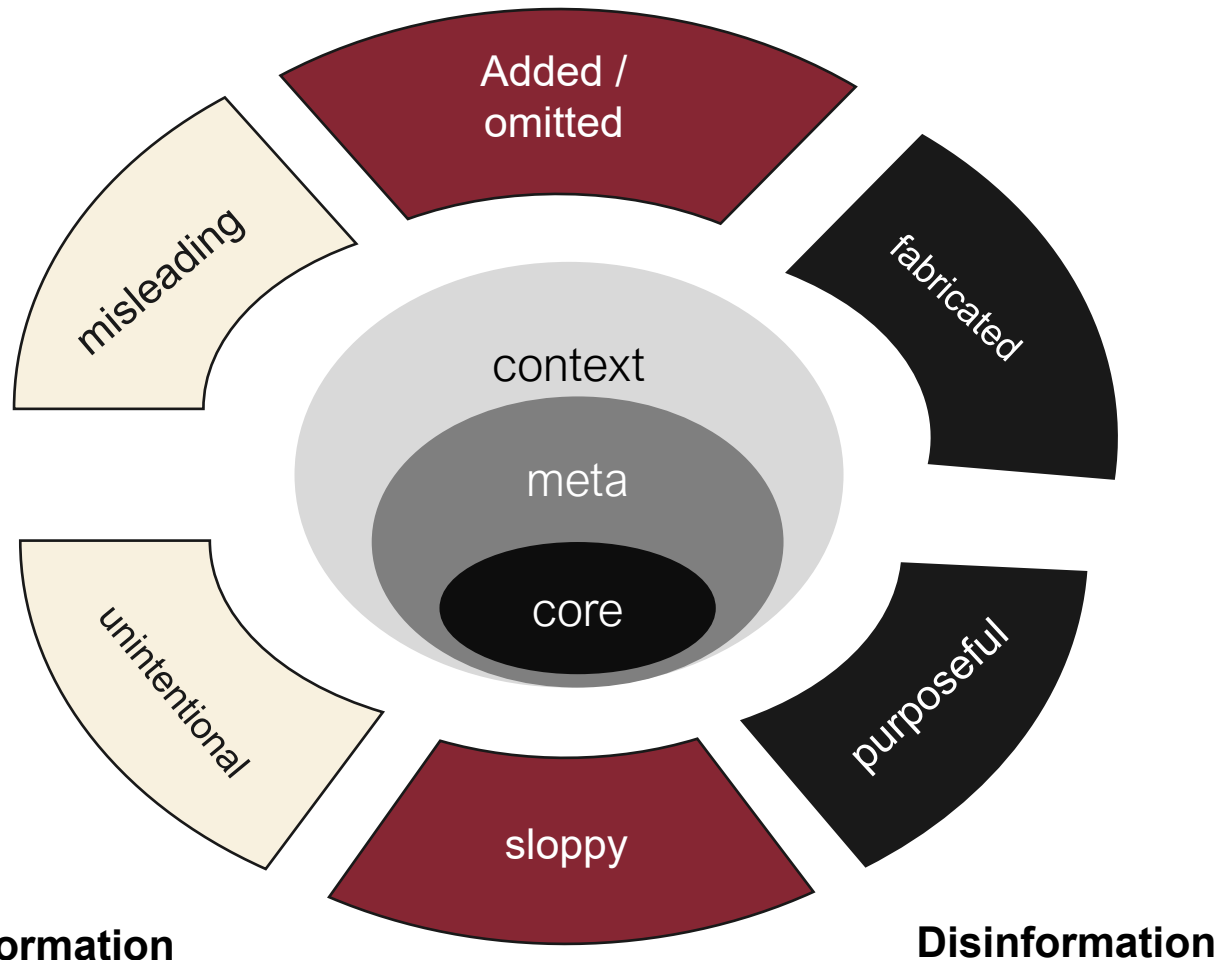
- Not so easy to define
- “Claims that, intentionally or not, at odds with the currently available best evidence”
- Bound to temporal dynamics, evidence can change
- Challenges:
 - Some claims are easier to confirm than others
 - Borders between misinformation, fiction, creative thinking, and entertainment can be blurred
 - Liberal pluralism: there is a democratic right to believe in silly things- as long as you tolerate others who believe in other silly things



Part of a larger information disorder

(Quandt et al., 2019; Wardle, 2018)

Via www.tjekdet.dk 2024



Typical disinformation campaigns (1)

(Jowett & O'Donnell, 2012; <https://euvsdisinfo.eu/no-denmark-is-not-legalising-sexual-abuse-of-animals/>)

- Placing the deception in a (seemingly) credible environment
- Afterwards: referring to the „credible“ source
- E.g., the “dog brothels in Copenhagen” story was first published by a marginal Russian outlet
- Then being taken up by RIA – the public Russian news agency
- Circulated across different countries and fed into narratives of Western moral corruption



<https://x.com/BolloDeanna/status/1205954112598216704>

#bandogbrothels



Will you turn the other way like those before you? Or contact a government official



Typical disinformation campaigns (2)

(Bond, 2023; Jowett & O'Donnell, 2012; Ryan et al., 2023)

- Simulation of a (seemingly) credible source
- The source spreads the deception
- The actual senders are no longer detectable
 - E.g., Video competitions by the Chinese government for online bloggers
 - Afterwards, they reported about “farming life” in Xingjian (were the Uyghur minority is subject to religious persecution and forced labour)
- Other example: LLM-seeding

Figure 4: Screenshot from YouTube shows Israeli vlogger Raz Gai-Or in a “YChina” vlog about cotton farming in Xinjiang. On the right, YouTube recommends further state-aligned vlogs on Xinjiang from foreign influencers, including those who have participated in PRC state-run short-video competitions. The screenshot was taken while accessing YouTube via a Washington DC VPN server, on 22 May 2023, with the US selected as ‘country’ in YouTube settings.



Source: YouTube.

Via Bond et al. 2023

Typical disinformation campaigns (3)

(u.a., Sutton & Douglas, 2020 ; Uscinski et al.,2022, Van Prooijen & Douglas, 2017; van der Heide, 2013)

- Dissemination of conspiracy theories to fuel societal conflict lines

Conspiracy theory:

- ...explanation of historical/ current/ future events through the secret and malicious action of powerful group (the conspirators)
 - ...often
 - patterns behind events, that are plausible, unconnected („best available evidence“)
 - in opposition to the general knowledge („counter-hegemonial“)
 - Not always false, but can be more or less unjustified and anti-democratic
- Also used in political communication
In 2002, the Bush administration and Tony Blair began speaking of weapons of mass destruction in Iraq and suggesting that they would go to Al-Qaeda
 - The invasion of Iraq was justified by the war on terror and the “axis of evil”



US Secretary of State Colin Powell holding a model vial of anthrax while giving the presentation to the United Nations Security Council on 5 February 2003

How big is the problem?

Prevalences and effects

Prevalence rates are difficult to determine

Different Sources

1. Monitoring/ Content analyses
2. Subjective experience
3. Platform information
4. Safety authorities

Out of 9354 Danish Tweets in March 2020 about facemasks, only

5% engaged with misinformation,

3% spread it

(Johansen et al. 2022)

Out of 1040 Danes

66% are concerned about misperceptions about Denmark due to misinformation

(Center for Sociale Medier, Tech og Demokrati, 2023)

PET warns from illegal foreign interferences aimed at sowing polarisation and conflict

Out of 410 Danish children aged 5-12

90% say that they have seen misleading content online

(Adler-Berg et al., 2025)

Misinformation effects as persuasion process

(Chaiken, 1980; Kahnemann, 2012; Petty & Cacioppo, 1986)

- Persuasion is typically described a two-process model
 - Elaboration-Likelihood Model
 - Heuristic-Systematic Model
- Based on the two cognitive processes (System I & System II)
 - Path 1: Fast, heuristic, peripheral
 - Path 2: Slow, elaborated, central
- General observation: heuristic processing is driven by biases, short-cuts and heuristics and does not lead to long-term attitude change
- Systematic or central “System II” processing leads to sustainable persuasion



John Cacioppo & Richard Petty via
<https://smileworking.blogspot.com/2010/09/elaboration-likelihood-model.html>



Shelley Chaiken
<https://chaiken.socialpsychology.org/>

Why do people fall for misinformation? (f. an overview,

s. Pennycook & Rand, 2021)

(1) Cognitive style

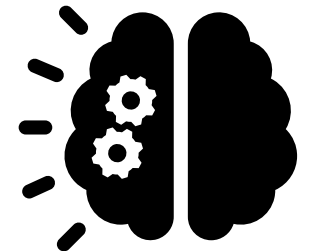
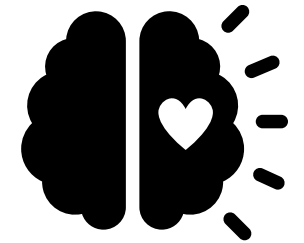
Misinformation is often not processed carefully, but heuristically
("System I" only)

Persons with

- ... a more pronounced "bullshit" receptivity (tendency to infer meaning from fancy words)
- ... a low need for cognition
- ... a lower cognitive performance capacity

... tend to believe more in misinformation

But: Unclear how "lasting" the misperception is

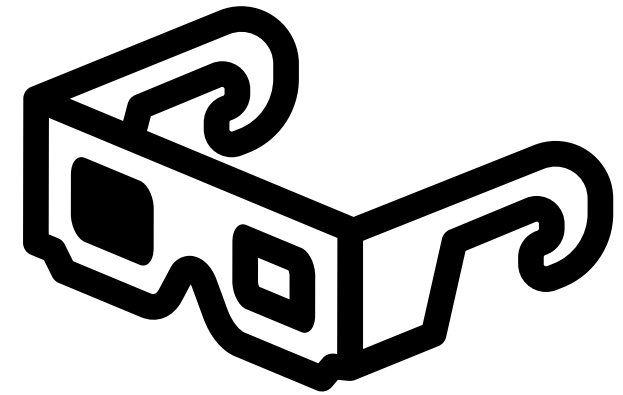


Why do people fall for misinformation?

(Faragó et al. 2020; Kunda, 1990; Koch et al. 2023; Pereira et al., 2021; Tajfel & Turner, 2004)

(2) Motivated cognition

- Basic idea:
 - Preference for content that confirms one's own worldview
 - Preference for content that puts the ingroup in a good light
- For example, voters are more likely to believe disinformation that puts their party in a good light or makes the other party look bad



Why do people fall for misinformation?

(Goertzl, 1994; Imhoff & Bruder, 2014; Sutton & Douglas, 2020; Uscinski et al. 2022; van der Linden et al., 2020; Wood et al., 2012)

(3) Generalized ideological attitudes: Conspiracy mentality

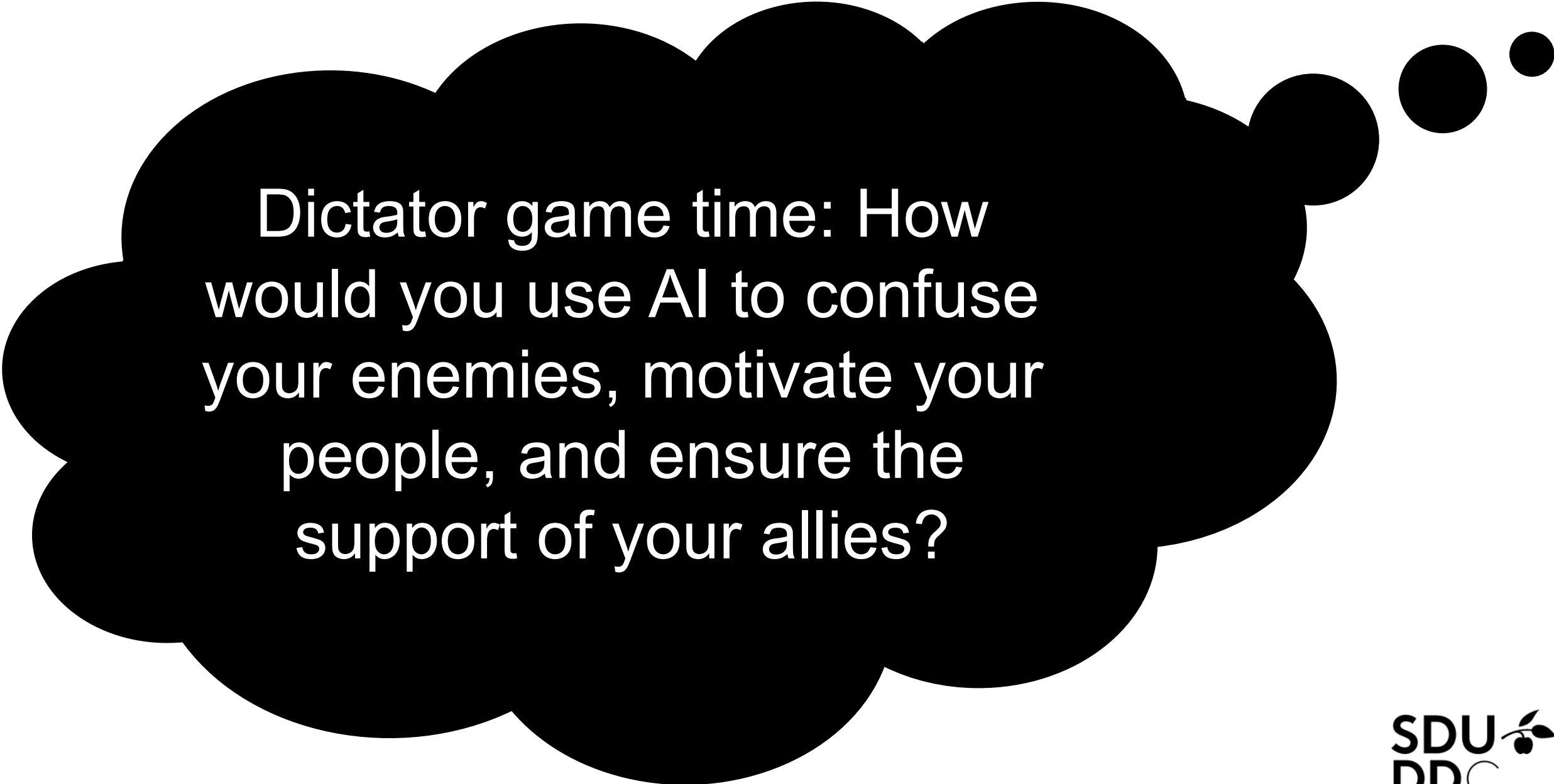
Disposition to suspect conspiracies behind significant events

- Fundamental (*not* constructive) mistrust towards influential people and institutions
- Belief in various conspiracy narratives
- More frequent at the extremes on both sides of the ideological spectrum
- Strength of the correlation asymmetrical: Right > Left
- Over time and contexts, shares are relatively stable in the general population



How does misinformation affect politics?

- The consumption of conspiracy theories can...
 - undermine confidence in democratic institutions (van Prooijen et al., 2022)
 - weaken the willingness to engage in normative political participation, such as voting
(Einstein & Glick, 2015, Kim & Cao, 2016, Pummerer et al., 2020)
- The consumption of misinformation can...
 - ...lead to misperceptions (Nielsen et al., 2021)
 - ...block the retrieval of the correct information from memory (Fazio et al. 2013)
 - ...become more credible when repeated (Fazio et al. 2019)
- Misinformation likely does not shape voting behavior at scale or turn recipients into zombies
- Plus, “doom speak” can also have adverse effects (Jungherr & Rauchfleisch, 2024)



Dictator game time: How would you use AI to confuse your enemies, motivate your people, and ensure the support of your allies?

Questions?



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Then I hope now you have...

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